



AMBUSHED:
Chaos outside Indian
Embassy in Kabul

PNA

neighbours AFGHANISTAN

WHY INDIA IS THE NEW TARGET

The suicide attack by ISI-backed Taliban militants on the embassy in Kabul is aimed at derailing India's reconstruction efforts in Afghanistan which has earned it considerable goodwill

■ By Saurabh Shukla with
Danish Karokhel in Kabul

When India launched its two Afghanistan campaign seven years ago after the fall of the Taliban in 2001, it knew that the road to Kabul would be perilous. As Delhi successfully made deep inroads into Afghanistan and established a firm rapport with the Hamid Karzai Government, there were two powerful foes—the remnants of Taliban and Pakistan, both of whom were upset by the turn of events. The Taliban was never friendly towards India and even had backed the hijacking of IC 814 to Kandahar in December 2001. Pakistan was still smarting over the loss of

control over what it considered its strategic backyard and objected to India's growing influence inside its neighbour. With the revival of the Taliban in Afghanistan, these two virulent anti-forces were out to undermine India's hold. Last week, if Indian and Afghanistan intelligence are to be believed, the deadly suicide bomb attack on the Indian Embassy in Kabul killing four Indians including two senior diplomats and 54 Afghans while injuring over 140, was masterminded by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) and outsourced to the Taliban cadres being armed and funded by Islamabad.

The timing of the attack is a clear indicator of the fact that security situa-

tion in Afghanistan runs the risk of getting back to a reign of chaos and anarchy, and the regime of Karzai and the NATO-led International Security Assistance Force along with the US forces have been unable to check it. The attack seemed to be part of the well-calibrated exercise to prevent India from undertaking reconstruction projects which are aimed at bringing peace and stability to war-ravaged Afghanistan. Pakistan had repeatedly asked the Afghan Government and even the United States to force India to shut its consulates in Afghanistan, which have been instrumental in reaching out to Afghan people.

The attack was the deadliest in Kabul since the ouster of Taliban